

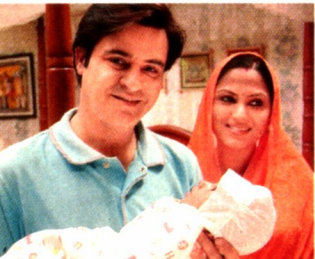
RISE OF THE SUPER GIRLS

The daughter becomes the new TRP trick and channels cash in on copycats

Weepy bahus can say bye-bye. On prime time TV today, the bouquets are for the betis. Married or single, infant or adult, working or growing up—the possibilities are endless. Ekta Kapoor flirted with the story of the wonder woman way back in 2001 with *Kkusum* on Sony. But it was *Bidaai* on Star Plus with which the



BHASKAR PAUL



STILLS FROM *LAADO* (ABOVE); *NANHI PARI* ON COLORS AND *SABKI LAADLI BEBO* ON STAR PLUS (RIGHT)

idea's potential came to the fore. And with *Balika Vadhu* on Colors, this genre blossomed. Soon, every channel was ready with its distressed daughter saga. Colors leads the pack with four shows—*Uttaran*, the story of a domestic help's daughter; *Laado* tackles female foeticide and has made its way to number eight with a TRP of 3.77 and *Nanhi Pari* celebrates the girl child. *Sabki Laadli Bebo* on Star Plus is about a family's love for their daughter while two shows on NDTV

Imagine—*Bandini* with a TRP of 1.5 and *Jyoti* with a TRP of 1.2 portray the struggle of young women. Zee TV, in the middle of putting out new content, began the process with *Agle Janam Mohe Bitiya Hi Kijo*. Set in Bihar, the story is about a girl who is eventually sold to an older landlord. Sony's latest fiction, *Kabhi Socha Na Tha*, is again about a poor girl's love and loss. With women contributing to 55 per cent of the viewership pie in March 2009, up by a percentage point from last year, channels are making sure they get enough female fodder.



Purnendu Shekhar, 47

Writer, *Balika Vadhu* on Colors

When Purnendu Shekhar came to Mumbai in 1997, he wanted to be an actor. But today, the 47-year-old can declare with pride that he's a writer, the man behind the story of *Balika Vadhu*, the genre-defining show on Colors. Shekhar, proficient with the social set-up and customs of Rajasthan, has set most of his stories in the region. His earlier success on Zee TV, *Saat Phere*, the story of a dark-skinned girl was set in an affluent yet traditional Rajasthani family, as is *Balika Vadhu*. "Child marriage as a subject has haunted me because it's very common in Rajasthan," he says of the story he wrote in 1992. He's been turning down offers to do other child marriage soaps. He is, after all, the man who wrote *Astitva* in 2003, Ajai Sinha's Zee TV show, which was unusual in its focus on the single woman.

the 11-year-old child bride of *Balika Vadhu*. Unlike Ekta Kapoor's bejewelled bahu, Anandi doesn't mouth lengthy monologues and still rustles up enough drama. Then there are Ragini and Sadhna, the two sisters of Star Plus' Agra-based *Sapna Babul Ka Bidaai*, who chose cotton salwar kameezes over kanjeevarams.

Shot nowhere near Sankraman Studios in Goregaon, where most Balaji soaps were housed, the crews now toil hard in distant Mumbai suburbs of Mira Road and Vikhroli, far from the deafening din of the Western Express Highway. If Star Plus' *Bidaai* is shot at two sets in a small studio at Mira Road, *Balika Vadhu*'s set at RC Dairy off the Ahmedabad-Mumbai highway could well be mistaken for someone's farmhouse. The sets have

given up their carved banisters and impossibly-high ceilings. "Gimmicks had gained importance instead of actors," says Rajan Shahi, who owns the year-and-a-half-old Director's Kut, the production company for *Bidaai* and *Yeh Rishta Kya Kehlata Hai* on Star Plus.

On TV, it's time for real characters and simple stories to trounce OTT bahu and multiple generation leaps. And there is a reason. Nine years ago when *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Thi* ushered high-pitched drama, the audience was largely urban and middle-class. "Their aspirations were big house and beautiful daughters-in-law," says Shailja Kejriwal, executive vice-president, content, NDTV Imagine. But in 2009, the growth in cable TV households in urban India has remained static at 20 per cent while it has grown



per cent is Colors' share in the Hindi general entertainment space, while the dethroned Star Plus trails at 22 per cent